

Yet, the stadium's biggest flaw lies in its accessibility. Located 30 kilometres south east of the town centre in the newly planned greenfield town of Nava Raipur, the journey to the venue is far from convenient for players, officials, and spectators alike. What should be an extraordinary cricketing experience is often marred by the logistical challenges of simply getting there.

Modern vibe

While India's premier domestic tournament — the Ranji Trophy — and its camps are still being held at the stadium, the grassroots cricketing ecosystem needed a more accessible alternative. Recognising these challenges, the CSCS sought a solution for nurturing young talent, resulting in the development of a state-of-the-art indoor cricket academy, seven kilometres away from the town centre.

This modern facility boasts eight full-sized net pitches equipped with bowling machines, a two-floor gym, a recovery room, and a sauna, providing players with a top-class environment to train, regardless of the stadium's logistical issues. Additionally, the academy features a 60-metre ground, fully functional for age-group cricket.

The academy hosts marquee tournaments like the U-14 Raj Singh Dungarpur Trophy, alongside selection trials for all age groups and across genders. Despite only becoming a full member of the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) in February 2016, the CSCS has been laying the groundwork to compete with long-established cricketing states.

"We have around 8,600 players registered with our association and

employ 52 coaches, 10 physios, 15 strength and conditioning trainers, and 16 selectors," said Ajay Kumar, a member of the CSCS, to *Sportstar*, underscoring the significant strides the state has made in developing cricketing infrastructure and talent.

Leggie's charm

Lucknow, the city of Nawabs and a haven for succulent, appetising non-vegetarian delicacies, embraced a new flavour during the opening round of Ranji Trophy fixtures at the Ekana Stadium.

Making his First-Class debut in the match against Bengal was young leg-spinner Vipraj Nigam (**below**). The 20-year-old, from Barabanki, just across the Faizabad highway, had the locals ecstatic after an incisive spell on the first evening.



SANDEEP SAXENA

Bengal, thanks to a hundred from opener Sudip Chatterjee, had raced to 212 for one when Nigam managed to dismiss Sudip Gharami for 90, finding the edge as he attempted a drive through cover. In the next 15 minutes or so, the leggie had breached the defences of captain Anustup Majumdar and trapped Wriddhiman Saha lbw with two googlies. A quick pick-up and throw from him also caught Abishek Porel short of his crease.

Early the next morning, as the diary trudged towards the ground to observe the warm-up session, the security guard at the entrance to the outfield struck up a conversation. "He's from our Barabanki," he exulted, raving about Nigam's exploits the previous evening. A similar sentiment echoed in the media box, where the scorer too seemed in awe of the youngster's spell.

Despite gaining only one point from the encounter, Uttar Pradesh could take positives from the performances of Nigam and the other two debutants, Swastik Chikara and Siddarth Yadav, who played two stroke-filled knocks in the first innings.

"Very, very happy with their performance," said skipper Aryan Juyal post-match. "When you take such risks, it comes with repercussions. *Agar aise nahi hua toh aap poochte ki maine aisa kyun kiya* (If it had not paid off, you would have asked me why I made that decision)," he added with a smirk.

Trip down memory lane

Former India Under-19 captain Priyam Garg found himself in an amusing moment on the field after he dived forward at cover to stop a ball, only to land awkwardly and bang his knee on the turf.

As the physio tended to the superficial wound with antiseptic, Garg winced in pain, requiring a couple of teammates to hold him down. It was a scene that many who've experienced the sharp sting of a scraped knee during a street-cricket game could easily relate to.